Ryanair lashes out at Air France and Lufthansa over ownership probe

送信者: POLITICO Pro Article 受信日時: 2026-10-10 01:35

【メール原文】

BRUSSELS — Ryanair has accused rivals Lufthansa and Air France-KLM of trying to ground the low-cost carrier by alleging that its ownership structure v
Pro is better in the app.
Click here to download.

Ryanair lashes out at Air France and Lufthansa over ownership probe
By Tommaso Lecca · Oct 9, 2026, 6:34 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — Ryanair has accused rivals Lufthansa and Air France-KLM of trying to ground the low-cost carrier by alleging that its ownership structure violates EU rules.

The two legacy airlines, which face growing competition from budget carriers, belong to the European Network Airlines Association, a lobby group that has filed a legal challenge over Ryanair's share ownership.

"Now they're in the Irish High Court seeking to have our license suspended and Ryanair grounded," Ryanair CEO Michael O'Leary said Thursday in Brussels.

The association confirmed to POLITICO that it has spent months urging EU and Irish aviation authorities to investigate whether Ryanair complies with the bloc's ownership and control rules.

Under those rules, airlines must be majority-owned and effectively controlled by EU nationals or entities to hold an EU operating license. ENAA argues that Ryanair no longer meets those requirements, pointing to the airline's March announcement that only 30% of its shares are held by EU nationals. O'Leary, an Irish citizen, holds 4% of the stock.

When the Irish Aviation Authority seemed "reluctant to engage on the matter," ENAA took the matter to court. If Ryanair loses the case, it could be forced to change its ownership structure. The carrier's operating license would only be suspended if it does not comply with the verdict.

Ryanair has rejected the allegations, arguing that its non-EU shareholders do not have voting rights, which means the airline is under EU control.

In an emailed statement, Ryanair accused its rivals of attempting "to restrict competition and choice for EU air travel" by challenging its operating license.

Grounding risk seen as remote

Augusto Viansson Ponte, a London-based director at Alton Aviation Consultancy, doubted that the legal case would be easily dismissed, but also said it was unlikely that Ryanair would lose its operating license.

“ENAA’s request is sufficiently well-founded to justify examination, but it is way too early to say that Ryanair is violating the rules,” he said.

Regardless of the legal outcome, Viansson Ponte said that a “likely first step would be corrective measures, not immediate grounding.”

Even if the court rules against the budget airline, Ryanair would have several options to address any compliance problems, the analyst said.

“Ryanair could restrict non-EU [share] purchases, facilitate transfers of shares to EU investors, implement targeted share buybacks or restructure its licensed subsidiaries for example,” he said, adding that the process “should be manageable” for the airline.

Enemies in court, friends in Brussels

Despite their spat, Ryanair, Lufthansa and Air France-KLM all belong to the Brussels-based Airlines for Europe (A4E) lobby, and all are pushing for a reform of the Air Services Regulation , which sets the rules for operating in the EU, including ownership and control.

The lobby’s members jointly support providing “more flexibility ⋯ and tackle the risks linked to this change,” they said in feedback to the Commission.

“The potential way forward is to allow institutional investors from selected third countries to hold a limited percentage of shares ⋯ which would count towards the EU share of ownership,” the joint position adds.

If EU lawmakers adopt the proposal, “that would allow a greater access to liquidity in those markets for airlines,” said easyJet CEO Kenton Jarvis, whose company is set to be acquired by U.S. investment firm Apollo.

However, the legal battle between the Irish budget airline and legacy carriers may fracture A4E. O’Leary threatened on Thursday at an A4E press conference to leave the lobby group unless the legal case is dropped by the end of the year.

A4E later acknowledged that its members “may have differing views on certain issues, [but] we share a common interest in advancing our collective work for the benefit of European passengers, particularly in an increasingly complex and costly regulatory environment.”

Neither Lufthansa nor Air France-KLM commented on O’Leary’s threat to leave A4E.

Mobility Competition and Industrial Policy
Airlines Aviation Competition Courts Institutional investors Investment Lobbying Regulation Services Carsten Spohr Michael O'Leary (Ryanair CEO) European Commission Irish High Court France United States

---

Pro Intelligence Connections
Aviation – EU air services rules (revision)
CLOSED • Aug 12, 2025 - Dec 16, 2025

This email alert has been sent for your exclusive use as a POLITICO Pro subscriber. Forwarding or reproducing the article without the express, written permission of POLITICO Pro is a violation of the POLITICO Pro license agreement.

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp
Update settings | Unsubscribe from this email | Unsubscribe from all emails
POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium